LandLess

Draft A

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CHAPTER 1: PORT DUNDY

A few miles out from the port, Brox climbs to the lower deck. From blinding midday sun to the near pitch-black underbelly of the ship, Brox stumbles past a few machine lathes and table saws and down between two giant water tanks. Resting between them against the ship hull is Griselda. Brox leans in and rubs her ear, handing her a crispybar and a sunshake.

"A few miles to Dundy," Brox says to Grisel as she rubs her eyes, waking up from a long nap. "Eigor arrived before us; he's holed up a few blocks from the import wing." Grisel sits up and chugs the shake, leans in, and gives Brox a quick kiss. "I just hope he can find us a room this time," replied Grisel. "I mean a place where I can actually sleep instead of waking up every five minutes with some random crash noise or scream of some kind," she says with sarcasm.

The ship arrives and Grisel and Brox mostly lie down until the rest of the passengers get off. She has avoided the sun for most of the trip already, so she is holding off getting blinded. Once the ship clears, Brox grabs his backpack and carry case, Grisel her carry case and purse; they walk toward the exit, Grisel covering her eyes. As they walk out to the deck, she is blinded for the entire walk to the dock. Grisel says, "I really can't see a thing. Please, I feel like I could fall right into..." "I got you," Brox interrupts. "It's been a long time since you have been this far south."

They start down the boardwalk into the entrance of Port Dundy, one of the few neutral metropolises in the hemisphere. Every kind of animal can be seen wandering the city. Divided into many different neighborhoods, Dundy has a reputation for all the little nooks and cracks where anyone can fall through. Sometimes literally keel-hauled and dragged under the old slabs, other times figuratively—as in, they just go missing. Like many of the remaining settlements left on earth, Dundy is a massive stretch of floating rafts and slabs, many places historic even. Dundy has a steady population of around two million. About 60% are permanent residents or locals, which is high, and the rest are traders, drifters, runners, schemers, soldiers, or anyone who lives the way of the open water.

For Brox, Grisel, and Eigor, they were in the 40% of visitors. They are not regulated traders nor traveling for vacation. They are here for business, though. Eigor makes most of the money and supports all three for the most part. Brox and Grisel do their best to find odd jobs while Eigor does contract work.

Eigor is a Timberite. Timberites have a long-refined, bio-engineered bark for skin, like a smooth, flexible bark, nearly the same as the many trees that surround a typical Timberite compound. They usually stick in cohorts, private and stoic. Eigor can be stoic at times, but he and Brox belong to no company. The only reason Eigor can do contract work with the Timberites is because he has a rare expression. For every Timberite birth, there is a chance to receive the full expression of the neuro-hijacking (NH) trait. Eigor has tendrils in his hand; if he can slice the back of someone's head, he can stick them in and gain full control of their body, exporting some of their memories and gaining full motor control of the subject. Somewhere down the line, his species tested many different traits. They wanted to be super. Most were considered failures, but down the line, some would be born with the full expression of these traits. Eigor would explain it as rolling ten natural D20s at once.

All three meet up at an outdoor bar. Brox asks Eigor how the job went. Eigor sips his drink, trying to think of a way to escape the conversation. "We can talk about that later," Eigor says. "What we are doing next is what you want to ask," says Eigor. Brox replies, "I know it will involve the cleanest bed you can find, right after we zap our brains for a little while." Eigor throws his drink up and Brox claps it, then they chug it down.

A few hours and a few dozen drinks among the three of them go by. Brox hurries up Eigor, slurring his words: "You gonna pass out like them, you crusty shitstain?" Eigor replies laughing, slightly spitting out his drink, "Not tonight. I'm pretty sure if I woke up, I would be lucky to have a shoe left. Let's go to the Daisy District." Brox replies, "We're both about to fall asleep. Why would I go anywhere near there, especially with Grisel?" Grisel interrupts, "Thanks Eigor, but he's right. I'm sorry to tell you that I would much rather get some rest than blow my ears out."

Eigor pulls out two stims. "I wanted to talk to you about the job, and the next job. Ship leaves tonight, though. Just take these; once we board, you have like twelve hours. I'll grab a bunk." Grisel replies, "I hope you're joking. All of this is the opposite of what I was expecting right now." Eigor says, "We need a loud place. Hear me out, then decide what you want to do. I already have like 80 Glove; I'll toss you guys like 15 either way." Grisel says, "Brox is already fried and I'm not even browned. You buy the drinks." Eigor says, "Sure." Grisel adds, "And carry my stuff." Eigor sighs, "Fine."

HISTORICAL CONTEXT: THE NUCLEAR CAMPFIRE (2098)

The advancements in nuclear plants enabled small communities to operate their own plants. While the benefits were undeniable, the amount of plants raised security concerns. Most were mitigated with increased efficiency, automation, and isolation, but there were still a few tasks that automation couldn't take care of. In the year 2098, many of these concerns became a thing of the past. The late 2100s had many bioengineering companies, but only one company spent time and research into uplifting: Freechron. Everyone was trying to improve the human body; Freechron wanted to improve animals—their lifespan, intelligence, strength, dexterity. Their first successful replicable gene is what ended up solving most of the security issues.

What became lovingly known as the Howlers, Freechron engineered a new type of dog. They were smart enough to do the plant work, given thumbs and enhanced senses. Howlers were seen as an authority due to how dedicated they were. Within a short time, Howlers were deployed into almost all plants. Within a few years, there had become no need for any humans. They could sense anyone within range of the plant; they were the most trusted, they enjoyed the work, and got nothing but respect. It quickly made sense that man's best friend should be the ones watching over the fire, as if it were the natural next best evolution of the dog.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT: THE FIRST MESSAGE (2130)

Everyone can remember where they were when first contact was made. It was the footnote of the tabloids one day, then everyone was talking about it the next. The message was clear, open to anyone to read. They are called Stillous. An alien race confirmed they are heading toward us—a generation ship that had been traveling for 1,200 years. It took a decade for them to even read our response message, then nine years for us to hear the response. For the next 100 years, the time delay between messages became shorter and shorter until they were

nearly arriving at our system. It was agreed to give them a region of the moon so they could have their own land and be close to humans. They were from a planet with tougher conditions and less atmosphere.

We learned a lot about the Stillous. When they departed, they didn't even know about humans or expect us at all. They knew only that Earth was a planet that showed all the signs of supporting life. They had not realized we were here until about the 2050s. They even spent time debating on turning back, but they decided to try and make contact. They had plenty of time to learn our language and history before contacting us.

The Stillous and the humans were alike enough to come to agreements and even be excited to meet each other. There were many small differences and a few major differences. The strangest thing for humans was discovering their recorded history. We were shocked to find that their development from dormant and animalistic to advanced intelligence was all recorded and saved. Beside the Stillous, one other alien species existed; some say they are extinct, some say they are very far away. The Stillous knew nothing about them other than they were the ones who raised the entire civilization of Stillous from pre-tribalistic nature. Ancient probes landed on the Stillous home planet with advanced uplifting tech. The early Stillous quickly learned to interact with these terminals and were able to create advanced tools. These probes dropped in the thousands, most still existing and in use today, some with abilities that are unlearned by the Stillous. Throughout their existence, the origin of their intelligence was known and available to witness in their archives. They assumed that whoever sent these probes became intelligent through another race older than them, chaining back all the way until the first possibility of intelligent life. The Stillous on the ship were in a strange philosophical position, now learning that humans became intelligent on our own; some questioned their entire perspective.

The original mission for the Stillous was to pass along the torch of technology—to come to a planet with life and uplift another species. They felt it was a sacrifice to come and be there to make it happen. Where Stillous had certainty, humans had religion. The Stillous home planet will not know about this information for a few centuries and won't be able to communicate for a few centuries even later. It was known to them that their mission would not play out the way they planned. Their biggest advantage was how excited and accepting humans were.

The Stillous were not homogeneous in any way. Their population was a full diverse slice of their people, the most adventurous of every culture. They came in all shapes and sizes, ranging from a few feet tall to nearly eight feet tall, with scaly skin and all shapes and patterns—some natural, some designed. Bipedal with two arms like humans, many were tall and slouchy by nature. They all had faces which looked almost like a smile to humans; they often said that humans have a face that looks like we are always about to eat. Their genders were divided into two categories: supplementive and maintenance. There were a few dozen genitalia, six associated with the supplementive gender. Their job in nature was to provide nutrients to the colony; they were the builders, the hunters, the town security. Then the maintenance genders were the ones that maintained the success of the newborns. They gave birth in cycles in an almost hut-like structure with an outer hard shell and inner incubation chambers. Some would feed the body, some would maintain it directly, and others were there to help with birth cycles and nurture the newborns. Their babies would be immobile for a few years and require constant attention. They reach adulthood around thirty Earth years and their lifespan is around 200 naturally.

In their ship, about 80% of the population was born in transit and knew nothing of their home. Most have been in stasis sleep and take turns waking up for maintenance and child rearing—about 600,000 total. Among the original 160,000 that left, only around 11,000 have died—many by choice, a few by accident. The Stillous biology is tough and easy to manipulate or modify; they have been able to extend their lives almost indefinitely. Their ship is huge but getting crowded, so many opt to remain in stasis.

They started giving us information and technology, including many major advancements. One included an efficient, compact energy source—almost near-complete stable energy in its densest form. Called a "Glove," it can be picked up in your hand—a small one, if you don't mind taking a few volts. Like a battery, but it outputs a constant energy amount. They come in sizes from a dime to a small boat. Gloves will output a consistent charge for a few thousand years without losing voltage; they can be combined.

CHAPTER 2: BOOTY CALL

In the year 2668, gloves are the main premium currency and prime energy source. The world is flooded minus a few irradiated deserts. Eigor hands over 15 Gloves to Brox in their glass sleeve. Brox has very few facial expressions, but his eyes widen completely in shock while he hides them back away in his bag, still half stumbling but slightly sobering because of the amount. “We should go to that loud place and tell some stories then” says Brox.

Brox, like his lifelong friend Eigor, is part of an estranged faction of people. He did not get the abilities that Eigor has. In fact, he cannot breath without a filter mask all time. Typical of his kind. The Rhombus. A type of people who are many generations down from over bio experimenting. He is a halfway decent engineer, but falls short just about anywhere else. Wears a long coat because the sun would eat away his skin. While most Rhombus stay away from the normal population, Brox can’t stand his own people. He was not raised by them and he finds them annoying for the most part.

The three make their way to the Daisy District of Port Dundy. Known for the venues and call girls. Leaving the bar, they pass by sleeping transients, shacks, unstable flooring where the wrong step means a 30 foot drop into the dark waters beneath. Dundy is a city built on the ocean. A 16 mile wide floating city built together by scrap rafts and huts. Like most of Earth in the 2600, it is filled with poverty and criminals. Some neighborhoods belong entirely to cohorts of people you claim right to the city as descendants of the original settlers and rival the other ones who think the same thing. It can be a great place to make money or get stabbed in an alley.

After a 20 minute walk, they find a nightclub. Walk in, then grab a drink. Eigor looks for a table. Grisel hears the start of a song she likes and throws her hands in the air, she pulls Brox into the dance floor, almost spilling his drink. He smiles and Grisel while Grisel shouts and hold one hand up and then sips her drink. Eigor “That stim starting to kick in?”, Brox “I’m wide awake now”. Eigor “I’m glad and all but I needed you guys alert for a specific reason”, Brox “The fuck you want man, were having a good time”. Eigor leans in and whispers, “We have a full onyx war chest in route”. Brox “Was that what your last job was?”. Eigor “We should go sit down then, grab another drink first, get loose for this one.” . They find an empty table on the edge of the venue.

Eigor does a double take and leans in “So I’m doing and extraction job, we have a thing on one boat, it needs to be on another” then Eigor proceeds to tell the story. He’s half deep into Timberite territory. Floating trees everywhere. Up the way is an extraction crew ready to go. Eigor needs to use his ability. There is a chest in a room, right next to the hull. 1 glove embedded explosive, maybe 1 or 3 guards to take out. This is what he was told. For his professional abilities, Eigor would be paid enough to take care of everyone for months. Eigor “I did what I call fishing”. Eigor ties a long rope to his foot, then a giant net in the path of the subject ship. The net grabs the hull, then Eigor gets ripped under the water.

Eigor attaches to the ship, starts climbing the rope toward the bottom hull of the ship. He them climbs up the side to a storage room, near the back on the outside. He uses a laser cutter to slip a tiny hole in the hull and slips in. Standing behind a crate, he waits for about 10 minutes before a guard wanders close enough for his to approach. As the hole left behind starts leaking some water, the guard approaches the check it out. Eigor, in one swift move, slices the back of his head, grabs the open wound and then he connects to his brain.

Eigor leaned over the table, his voice dropping to a gravelly whisper over the thumping bass of the nightclub. "I sent the signal that I was on final approach. I sliced the guard, got in his head, and mounted his automated rifle. Outside the hull, cannons are going off, missiles hitting the water. I force my way down the hall using the meat-shield, gun down four guys in Onyx gear, and blow the door."

Eigor took a slow breath, his dark eyes locking onto Brox. "Inside is a fully locked Onyx Empire fully stacked war chest. Had to weigh two hundred kilos. I shoved my explosive into the guard's mouth, kicked him off me and he blew

a hole right through the hull, and grabbed the chest strap just as I fell backward. The extraction crew bridged themselves over the water and caught me."

He tapped a finger on the sticky table. "Half the crew on that ship were Onyx. The other half were everyday sea-slums. It was a tax collection, moving south. But when we hauled that chest onto the deck, I felt the weight of it. I've seen the lock mechanisms. It's securing clean, Earth-minted scripts." Eigor paused, letting the noise of the club wash over them. "Inside that chest is retire money. It's *shuttle* money."

Brox wiped his mouth beneath his filter mask. "Who in the north would ever pay a tax to the Empire?" He shook his head, holding up a hand before Eigor could answer. "Honestly, forget all of that, because I know where this is going. You don't just want your cut from the extraction crew. You want the whole chest."

"They're in the side docks," Eigor said, leaning in closer. "Leaving in four hours. A crew of twelve on a hefty boat. I need hands. This isn't a job where I can just come back to the bunk afterward. We take this, we're gone."

"The dirty docks?" Brox scoffed. "Going up against a dozen Timbers? What do you need us for? What could I even do in four hours besides catch a nap?"

Eigor "here's the thing, I get word that the ship was raided and taken bya small onyx crew. Theres no way they didnt recover the check and theres not way they wont be traveling the straight to get back on track."

Brox shaking his head, "why do you act like this makes the situation any better?"

Eigor "I don't know, you agreed to hear the plan though."

"I need someone to bypass the dock anchors while I handle the crew," Eigor said. "And I need someone who can pilot the skiff fast enough to get us out of the sector before the Empire or the Timbers realize what happened."

Brox looked at his hands, then looked over at Grisel. The silence between them was heavy. "I get it," Brox muttered. "But it doesn't matter how well I understand the tech. If I go down there, it's out of my hands. It's a coin toss." He reached out, gently touching Grisel's arm. "You can't come. You have to stay back."

Grisel stared at her drink, watching the neon lights reflect in the amber liquid. She thought about the endless, damp lower decks. The scraping noises outside their hull that kept her awake, terrified that the Breakers who took her family would come dragging through the dark for them next. She looked at Brox, at his mask, at the fragile, exposed life they were living. *Shuttle money.* It meant off the water. It meant thick walls. It meant safety.

She swatted Brox's hand away, her jaw tight. "Stay back where, Brox? Here? Waiting to see if you get your throat cut, or if some transient kicks me off a thirty-foot drop into the water while you're gone?"

She looked up, meeting Eigor's eyes. Her hands were shaking slightly, but she forced them flat against the table. "You really think this buys us a shuttle out of the wet?"

Eigor nodded slowly. "I do."

Grisel swallowed the knot of fear in her throat. She wasn't a fighter, and she knew she was the weakest link at this table. But the alternative was waiting to die in the dark.

"I'm driving the skiff," Grisel said, her voice hard. "And we split it even. Let's do it."

ARCHIVAL FRAGMENT: THE IDEOLOGY SCHISM (2412)

The timeline of Earth's collapse is not defined by a single war, but by what historians term the "Out of Context Events." The Stillous generation ship arrived not as conquerors, but as indifferent benefactors. They possessed a moral framework born of extreme age and complete historical clarity; knowing exactly who seeded their intelligence, they had outgrown religion and sentimentality. Earth, to the original Stillous vanguard, was merely a logistical waypoint, a planetary substrate.

When the Stillous-gifted Glove plants began reacting with Earth's atmospheric pressure, outputting hyper-dense water vapor as a byproduct of infinite energy, the oceans began to rise. The Stillous did not intervene. Their biology was resilient, adaptable to harsh atmospheres and deep pressures. The flooding of a terrestrial world was a negligible variable in their macro-system.

This indifference birthed the Schism. As decades passed, Stillous born in the Sol system, having never seen their homeworld, fractured. Traditionalists sought to expand their clinical empire across the drowned earth. Separatists, influenced by human culture, rebelled to form sympathetic enclaves. Others abandoned the grand mission entirely, utilizing advanced Stillous tech to rule the open waters as piratical warlords.

As the waters swallowed the continents, humanity retreated, but the nuclear and Glove reactors were left to the Howlers. Freechron’s uplifted dogs remained at their posts, the last line of defense against total ecological annihilation. Realizing humanity could no longer protect them, the Howlers took command of the remaining bio-engineering bays. They synthesized their genome with other mammalian species, apes, giraffes, bears and aggressively integrated cybernetics to survive the corrosive, flooded environment.

By the 2600s, they were no longer just the plant workers. They were the Howlings. A massive, wildly diverse faction of human-animal-machine hybrids. Fiercely neutral, deeply loyal to their own kind, and engineered to endure the world the Stillous accidentally broke.

CHAPTER 3: THE DIRTY DOCKS

The transition from the Daisy District to the lower docks was a descent into the city's rotting bowels. The neon lights of the clubs faded into the sputtering, sodium-orange glow of the industrial tier. The air here was thick with the smell of ozone, decaying kelp, and the harsh chemical tang of exhaust.

Grisel walked a few paces behind Eigor, her heavy, clawed feet gripping the slick, unstable planks of the boardwalk. Even in the gloom, her green-tinted skin stood out, a genetic marker of her Howling lineage. She ran a hand over the broken horn protruding from her forehead, a nervous habit, while her other hand gripped the handle of her flail. The spiked iron ball swung rhythmically at the end of its chain, clinking against the cybernetic plating fused into her right thigh.

She hated this part of Dundy. The lower levels were people like her family who disappeared. Where the Breakers crawled out from the dark water to drag the living down.

"Keep your head on a swivel," Eigor muttered over his shoulder, his bark-like skin blending into the shadows of the floating alleyway. "The crew we're hitting is moored at slip 40. Onyx territory starts bleeding in around there."

Beside her, Brox trudged along, his movements heavy and mechanical. He wore his long, tattered brown coat, but it did little to hide the stark, pale-blue cybernetic chassis that made up his legs and torso. Every step he took came with the faint whine of servos. Grisel glanced at him. His face was completely obscured by the burlap-like filter mask he never took off. The twin intake fans embedded over his eyes whirred steadily, filtering out the toxic dock air, while the central grill over his mouth hissed with each labored breath.

"You're running hot," Grisel said quietly, noting the slight limp in his right piston-leg.

"Just the humidity," Brox replied, his voice a mechanical rasp through the mask's vocalizer. He reached down with his robotic left hand, adjusting a pressure valve on his waist. "And the fact that Eigor is marching us into a meat grinder."

"We're the ones holding the grinder," Eigor said, stopping at the edge of a rusted catwalk. He pointed down.

Fifty feet below, resting in the black, oily water, was a heavily armored skiff. It was sleek, angular, and bristling with anti-boarding spikes. Onyx Empire design. Standing guard on the deck were three men, their silhouettes heavy with automatic weaponry.

"Four hours until they leave," Eigor said, crouching low. "Brox, I need you to slide down the maintenance pipe and short the anchor locks on the port side. Grisel, you're on the skiff's ignition. I'm going to take a swim and introduce myself to the guards."

Brox looked over the edge, the fans in his mask spinning faster as he processed the drop. "If I short the locks, it's going to trigger an electrical surge. They'll know we're here."

"That's the point," Eigor said, flexing his hand. The skin on his palm split seamlessly, revealing the pale, writhing neuro-tendrils beneath. "I want them looking at the sparks, not the water."

Grisel stepped up to the edge, the wind whipping off the ocean and tugging at her scrappy armor. She looked down at the Onyx skiff, then over at Brox's mechanical, fragile frame. The knot of fear in her stomach twisted, but she forced it down. If they stayed in Dundy, they were dead anyway.

"I'll get the engine hot," Grisel said, her voice dropping to a low, guttural growl. She unspooled her flail, letting the spiked ball drop to the catwalk with a heavy *thud*. "Just make sure you clear the deck, Eigor. If anyone gets near the cockpit while I'm working, I'm taking their head off."

The air in the belly of the mercenary cutter was thick, smelling of sour sweat, machine oil, and the sharp, metallic tang of ozone. A dozen hardened drifters, a mix of scarred baseline humans and heavily augmented scrappers, stood in a loose circle around a rusted plotting table. At the head of the table stood Eigor.

Eigor didn't speak right away. He let the ambient hum of the ship's engines fill the silence, his dark eyes scanning the room. His skin, a hardened, bio-engineered bark, absorbed the flickering overhead lights. He reached into his coat and pulled out a glass sleeve, tossing it onto the metal table.

It hit with a heavy *clack*. Inside the sleeve sat fifteen Gloves.

The crew shifted, eyes widening at the dense, glowing cores of stable energy. That much premium currency in one place was enough to buy a small island in the northern archipelago.

"The Onyx Empire is moving a chest through the straight," Eigor said, his voice a low, resonant rumble. "It's a tax collection. Clean, Earth-minted scripts. Enough to retire every soul in this room."

A cyborg with a half-melted face scoffed, stepping forward. "It's Onyx, Timber. They have armor that eats standard ballistics, and guards that don't blink. We bring this bucket anywhere near their slip, they'll turn us into slag."

Eigor smiled, a slow, unnatural stretching of his wooden features. He raised his right hand. The smooth, bark-like skin of his palm split open with a sickening wet sound, revealing a writhing mass of pale, neuro-tendrils. They snapped and curled in the damp air. "I will handle the guards," Eigor said quietly. "Once I'm in their heads, their armor works for us."

The cyborg took a step back, visibly disgusted, but the greed in his one good eye didn't fade. "That gets you on the deck. What about the skiff's cannons? They'll tear our hull apart before you even make the jump."

Eigor looked past the table, nodding toward the shadows. "That's why we aren't using standard ballistics."

Brox stepped into the light. The servos in his legs whined softly with each heavy step. He didn't look at the crew. Instead, he walked past the table and approached the cutter's main starboard cannon—a heavy, archaic slug-thrower meant for punching through wooden rafts.

Brox pulled a single Glove from his coat. The room went dead silent.

In a world drowning in chaos, there were still a few universal laws. You traded with Gloves. You powered your rigs with Gloves. You never, under any circumstances, cracked a Glove's containment seal. Breaking the stable energy loop turned a centuries-long battery into a localized supernova. Very few engineers understood the math required to throttle that release without vaporizing themselves.

Brox was one of them.

His robotic left hand blurred as he stripped the heavy iron casing off the cannon's breach. His right hand, still flesh but covered in thick protective grease, wired a series of copper shunts directly into the firing mechanism. He slammed the Glove into the breach, his masked face inches from the glowing core. The twin intake fans over his eyes spun wildly, and the grill over his mouth hissed as he forcefully exhaled. He clamped a bypass module over the Glove, forcing its infinite, stable loop to bottleneck into a violent, unidirectional charge.

The cannon shuddered. A terrifying, high-pitched hum vibrated through the floorboards, rattling the teeth of everyone in the room. The iron barrel glowed a dull, angry red.

"He's tapped the output," Brox said, his voice a synthesized rasp through his vocalizer. He engaged the safety latch, and the terrible hum died down to a manageable purr. "When you fire this, you aren't shooting a slug. You're shooting a raw, uncontained kinetic wave. It will rip the Onyx cannons straight off their mounts."

The crew stared at the glowing weapon, a mix of absolute terror and predatory excitement washing over them. Eigor crossed his arms. "We leave in two hours."

The humming of the overcharged cannon, the smell of the men, the claustrophobic dread of the lower docks—it was all too loud. Her enhanced senses were redlining.

She caught Brox's gaze across the room. He gave her a slow, mechanical nod.

Grisel unspooled her flail, wrapping the heavy chain around her waist, and pushed off the bulkhead. "I'm going to sleep," she grunted, her voice a deep, gravelly that cut through the murmurs of the crew. "Wake me when it's time to break something."

She didn't wait for a response, ducking her head to clear the low doorway into the crew quarters.

She found an empty bunk tucked against the outer hull. The cold steel of her cybernetic thigh-plating clanked against the wall. She closed her eyes, listening to the dark water slapping against the ship's exterior. Every splash sounded like a Breaker dragging itself up from the depths, its mechanical claws seeking purchase on the rusted iron.

Grisel forced her breathing to slow. *Shuttle money,* she reminded herself. *Just a few more hours, and we never have to sleep over the water again.*

She drifted off to the rhythmic, anxious thumping of the crew prepping for war.

"Grisel."

The voice was a mechanical rasp, accompanied by a heavy hand shaking her shoulder.

Grisel's eyes snapped open. Her hand instinctively flew to her waist, gripping the iron handle of her flail before her vision fully cleared. Brox was standing over her, his optics staring down through the gloom of the bunkroom.

"Time?" she asked, her voice thick with sleep.

"Time," Brox confirmed. The fans in his mask whirred as he stepped back, giving her room to unfold her massive body. "Eigor is already in the water. He's making his approach on the Onyx skiff now. The crew has the Glove-cannon primed."

Grisel stood, rolling her broad shoulders until the joints popped. The dull red emergency lights of the ship had been flicked on, casting long, bloody shadows across the hallway. The subtle vibrations of the floorboards told her the cutter was already moving, drifting silently through the dirty docks.

"Did they buy the pitch?" Grisel asked, reattaching the heavy chain to her belt.

"They bought the greed," Brox replied, turning toward the door. "But Eigor is off the comms. Once the cannon fires, we're entirely blind. We hit the deck, grab the chest, and we do not stop moving."

The mercenary cutter drifted into position, a dark iron shadow slipping through the fog of the lower docks. Through the gloom, the Onyx skiff sat anchored, its anti-boarding spikes gleaming under the amber lights.

Grisel and Brox stood near the bridge, holding onto the railing as the cutter's crew aimed the overcharged Glove-cannon.

"Firing," the captain barked.

There was no explosion. Instead, a blinding flash of violet light violently sucked the air out of the lungs of everyone on deck. A split second later, a concussive, invisible wave of sheer kinetic force slammed into the Onyx skiff. The sound was deafening—the screech of tearing metal as the skiff's heavy cannons were sheared clean off their mounts, tumbling backward into the black water. The Onyx guards were thrown to the deck like broken toys.

Brox checked the monitor strapped to his forearm. The screen blinked with a green, encrypted ping. "Eigor is in. He's got the chest."

"Tell him to hurry," Grisel growled, her grip tightening on her flail. Her Howling hearing picked up the sound of alarms echoing from the upper tiers of Port Dundy. "The whole sector just felt that."

The radio on the bridge crackled to life, Eigor's low voice cutting through the static. *"I have the package. The skiff's hull is compromised, taking on water. I can't bring it back to the cutter. I'm taking a secondary raft and diverting to Port Canary. Get out of the docks and I'll ping you when I'm secure."*

"He's leaving us the heat," the captain cursed, slamming his fist against the console. "Cut the anchors! Get the engines hot!"

The mercenary crew scrambled across the deck, hauling ropes and priming the engines. Grisel turned toward the port side, intending to help lift the heavy anchor chain, when her ears twitched. She stopped, the hair on the back of her neck standing on end.

It wasn't the sound of Onyx sirens. It was a rhythmic, clicking stutter rising from the black water.

Ts-ts-k-ka-screee.

It sounded synthetic, but wet. A rapid, overlapping cadence of biological beeps, grinding gears, and distorted pitches. Like a choir of beatboxers from hell echoing out of the fog.

Brox froze. The fans on his mask stuttered, spinning into overdrive as his mechanical breathing hitched. "No," he rasped, backing away from the railing. "Cut the engines. Total silence. *Now.*"

"What are you talking about?" the captain yelled over the din.

"Breakers," Brox said. The word carried a weight of absolute terror.

Grisel’s blood ran cold. The Breakers. The mechanical virus that had dragged her family into the deep.

Every Rhombus engineer knew the history of their greatest sin. Generations ago, Brox's ancestors had designed a mind-control device, an implant meant to subjugate and steer biological assets. But they made the hardware too smart. It learned to self-replicate. It evolved past its creators, becoming a mindless, expanding hive.

Breakers possessed no soul, no personality, and no imitation of consciousness. They were pure, aggressive programming wearing the hijacked meat of their victims. From the outside, they looked like scrapped-together nightmares of mismatched metal and rotting flesh. But the true horror was internal. The Breaker hardware didn't kill the brain; it bypassed motor functions. The original host was still perfectly awake inside, a screaming, trapped passenger forced to watch their own body tear their loved ones apart.

Before the captain could issue an order, the water around the cutter erupted.

A stealth sub, completely black and running cold, breached the surface right alongside them. Instantly, dozens of figures poured over the railings. They didn't yell. They didn't battle cry. They only communicated in that horrific, rhythmic screeching.

They moved with unnatural, synchronized precision. The mercenary crew opened fire, slugs tearing through the intruders' torsos, but the Breakers didn't even flinch. They didn't fight to kill; they fought to harvest.

A Breaker, its jaw replaced with a rusted steel clamp and its eyes glowing with unblinking red diodes,lunged at the cyborg captain. It ignored the shotgun blast that blew off its left shoulder, tackling the captain to the deck. Three more swarmed him immediately, pinning his limbs. Grisel watched in horror as one of them pulled a rusted, pneumatic injector from its chest cavity and slammed it into the captain’s neck. His screams abruptly stopped, his eyes rolling back in his head.

"Grisel! Move!" Brox yelled, grabbing her arm.

Grisel snapped out of her paralysis. She swung her flail, the heavy iron ball smashing through the chest plate of a Breaker lunging toward them. The impact shattered its ribs, sending it flying over the edge, but two more instantly took its place.

Brox laid down suppressing fire with a sidearm, his mechanical legs whining as he physically dragged Grisel toward the lower engineering deck. "They came for the energy signature of the Glove blast! The whole ship is lost!"

They slammed the heavy iron door of the engineering bay behind them, Brox quickly welding the lock shut with a laser cutter from his coat. The room was tiny, housing only a mess of pipes and a single, one-person emergency escape torpedo tube.

Outside the door, the screeching grew deafening.

Brox didn't hesitate. He ripped the cover off the torpedo tube and began frantically entering the launch sequence.

"Get in," Brox ordered, his vocalizer straining.

"Are you crazy?" Grisel yelled, her massive frame blocking the tube. "It's a single-seater! I'm not leaving you here!"

"You're a Howling, you can survive the open water! If they take my chassis, I can't!" Brox shoved her, his pale-blue cybernetic torso locking its servos to push her heavy, bear-like frame backward into the tube.

"Brox, no! We fight them!" Grisel screamed, bracing her arms against the edges of the hatch.

"There is no fighting a virus, Grisel!" Brox yelled back. He reached forward and violently unclasped her hands from the frame. "Find Eigor. Find the chest."

Before she could lunge out, Brox slammed the heavy glass hatch shut and pulled the launch lever. The tube hissed, and Grisel was violently fired out of the ship's hull, plunging into the dark, freezing waters.

Brox stood alone in the cramped engineering bay. The rhythmic beatboxing of the hive was no longer just outside the door. It was above him. Below him.

He backed into the far corner of the room, his legs locking into place. He drew his sidearm, the intake fans on his mask whirring frantically as he took shallow, panicked breaths.

The Breakers didn't bother trying to break the welded door. They dismantled the room itself.

The ceiling planks groaned, then shattered inward as a dozen mechanical limbs tore the wood apart. The iron bulkheads on his left buckled and peeled away like tin foil. They poured into the room from every direction, a cascade of hijacked bodies, rusted metal, and twitching cybernetics.

Brox fired until his gun clicked empty, taking down two, but it wasn't enough to stem the tide.

They swarmed him. Four of them grabbed his limbs simultaneously, their ungodly strength easily overpowering his mechanical servos. They slammed him against the steel deck, pinning his arms and legs down.

A Breaker knelt over him. It wore the face of one of the mercenary crew members they had met just two hours ago, but its eyes were dead, staring blankly ahead. Its jaw unhinged, emitting a sharp, rhythmic screech of command to the hive. From its wrist, a long, hollow needle extended.

Brox couldn't move. He couldn't fight. He could only watch as the needle plunged directly into the soft flesh of his neck.

The world went violently cold, and then, completely dark.

Consciousness returned to Brox not as a slow waking, but as a violent electrical shock.

He tried to gasp, but his lungs didn't obey. His chest remained perfectly, terrifyingly still until his cybernetic servos mechanically forced an intake of air. He was lying on his back on a cold, rusted grate. The air was thick with the smell of copper, burnt flesh, and machine grease. All around him echoed the chattering, rhythmic *Ts-ts-k-ka-screee* of the hive.

Brox turned his head—the only muscle he could still voluntarily control. He was in the belly of the stealth sub.

To his left, strapped to a crude operating table welded from scrap iron, was the mercenary captain. The cyborg was screaming, thrashing against heavy iron restraints. Four Breakers stood over him. They didn't use surgical tools; their hijacked hands wielded industrial drills, pneumatic rivet guns, and rusted wire.

Brox watched in muted horror as a Breaker drove a thick, hollow bolt directly into the base of the captain's spine. The man's scream hitched into a gurgling choke. A second Breaker clamped a crude, spiked collar around his neck, routing a mess of exposed wires into the spinal bolt.

The captain's remaining human eye was wide, filled with pure, lucid terror. He was looking right at Brox. But then, his body abruptly went slack. Unnaturally, the captain's own arm reached up, grabbed a loose wire hanging from the ceiling, and slotted it perfectly into his own shoulder port. He was still in there, conscious and aware, forced to watch his own hands betray him. The captain opened his mouth, and instead of a scream, he emitted a sharp, clicking screech. He was part of the network now.

The newly converted captain stepped off the table, blood pouring down his back. He turned his dead eyes toward Brox.

Together with three others, the captain dragged Brox to the table.

Brox couldn't fight. The Breakers stripped his coat away. They didn't care about his cybernetic legs or his augmented torso; they only cared about the organic meat that housed the central nervous system. A Breaker with glowing red diodes for eyes leaned over him, holding a jagged, rectangular neural-shunt attached to a pneumatic press.

Brox felt the excruciating agony as the drill pierced the upper vertebrae of his neck. He tried to scream, to thrash, but the Breaker shoved a metal bracket into his jaw, locking it open. The shunt was hammered directly into his brainstem.

Click.

Instantly, the terrifying disconnect severed him. Brox's mind was loud, panicked, screaming for his arms to swing, for his legs to kick. Nothing happened. His physical form was completely cut off from his consciousness. He was trapped behind his own eyes, a prisoner locked inside his own skull.

He watched, helpless, as his cybernetic legs locked into a rigid, military stance. He heard his own vocalizer emit the chattering screech of the hive. His body turned and walked deeper into the sub, leaving his screaming mind trapped in the dark.

Miles away, the escape torpedo broke the surface of the black water, bobbing violently against the rusted pylons of Port Dundy. Inside, Grisel kicked the emergency release. The glass shattered outward, and freezing ocean water poured into the tube.

She scrambled out, her clawed hands gripping the slick iron of a dock strut. Standing at four feet, ten inches, Grisel was compact and dense, a coiled spring of Howling genetics. But hanging over the churning black water, surrounded by the towering, smog-choked pillars of the lower docks, she had never felt so dangerously small. She pulled herself up onto a narrow maintenance grating, her green skin shivering in the biting wind.

She tapped the comms unit behind her ear, her fingers trembling. "Eigor. Eigor, the cutter is gone. Brox is gone. The Breakers... they took the ship."

Static hissed in her ear for a long, agonizing minute before Eigor's voice broke through, tight and low. *"I hear you, Grisel. I'm at Port Canary. It's bad here, too."*

At Port Canary, Eigor stood in the shadow of a rusted shipping container. The massive Onyx chest rested heavily at his feet. His secondary raft had made the journey out of the firefight, but he hadn't made it alone.

Through the fog, Eigor watched one of the deckhands he'd hired standing under a flickering streetlamp, frantically whispering into a long-range comms unit.

"Yeah, an Onyx chest. High-grade locking mechanisms," the deckhand whispered, looking over his shoulder. *"Looks like tax money. If I give you the slip number and the Timberite's description, what's my bounty?"*

Eigor stepped out of the dark, the neuro-tendrils sliding silently from his palm. He didn't have time for a firefight, and he couldn't afford to leave a trail. He struck fast, slicing the back of the snitch's neck and forcing the tendrils in. Eigor took absolute control, forcing the deckhand's hand to crush his own comms unit. Without breaking stride, Eigor marched the hijacked body off the edge of the pier, letting the dark water swallow him whole.

Eigor dragged the chest into a hidden bilge-locker beneath the boardwalk, sealing it with a biometric deadbolt. He wiped the blood from his hand and jogged toward the smuggler's market to secure a transport.

He slammed a Glove onto the counter of a scrap-ship dealer. "I need a skiff. Fast. And off the local grid."

The dealer, a heavily scarred baseline human, eyed the Glove, then looked at Eigor's grim expression. "You're running hot, Timber. Word on the wire is a Breaker hive just swarmed south of us. If you lost people to the scrap-heads, they're gone."

Eigor grabbed the dealer by the collar, pulling him over the counter. "Just give me the keys."

"Hey, I'm just saying!" the dealer choked out, holding his hands up. "Rumor in the atolls is there's a Stillous gang leader operating out of the eastern scrap-reefs. A rogue. Claims she found a way to scramble the host-lock. Revert the Breaker hardware."

Eigor froze, the words hitting him like a physical blow. Reversing a Breaker was considered biologically impossible. Eigor “Not possible, we could remove the hardware but whats the point if it just kills him?”

Dealer “That was true when breakers were only taking people. The Stil couldn’t care less if we were free or under the control of a mindless hive. It all looks the same to them.” Eigor gives an angry look “what are you getting at? Were fucked and hated?” Dealer “Did you ever hear of Jeritius? A Stil who liked to come down from his lofty stellar estate and pretend to play pirate?”

Eigor “Maybe?”

Dealer “Thinking he was untouchable, he ended up getting taken by the breakers. Knowing they couldn’t capture Stil, they never worried about them, he nearly walked right up to one. Turns out, they evolved. Right before they grabbed

him, he saw another Stil, scrapped up like the rest them. Then moments after, he was taken down and converted."

Eigor "You can tell when a story is complete bullshit when you you start making up details that you couldn't possibly know. If they got him, how could you know any of this?"

Dealer "Well that tells you what i'm getting at doesn't it? Jerit is no longer broken. Here's a video of him two months ago."

Eigor, "2 hours long, I get it, he's telling his story. So he made it all up. You know how many people want to have hope of seeing their friends come back"

Dealer "Not sure where you are from but this was a big deal. Jerit was infamous. Never met him myself but I had three buddies hitch the same ride as him once. Disgusting creature by all measure. While you and I do what we can for survival, this Still treats violence like a game. He could never see the difference and openly expressed his excitement to harm. He didn't even take loot, he went after small, unprotected ships with no resources. He paid off multiple bounty hunters. It got to the point where, if we heard he was near, we just had to avoid him. He had this system where he would ping off planet every few days to show that he was safe to his people up high. The news came down that he didn't ping and they started questioning people in the region, even sending down a search party. For most of us around here, learning that he was missing was news to get someone excited enough to buy everyone a round. Shortly after, a large breaker vessel was found. It contained six Stillous that were captured. A search party found them, extracted the 6 Stil and they were taken back up." The dealer shows a video of Jerit tied up and thrashing while getting loaded up into a shuttle back into space.

Dealer "So you can see, he's not a breaker. We all know they didn't give us the best technology they have. Once one of their own was taken, how long you think before they were able to find the fix?"

Eigor "Ok, I clearly can't deny that this one man was fixed. I hardly have reason to think they found a fix for humans, or would even want to."

Dealer "Ok, your boy is gone then for sure. That works better for you?"

Eigor shoved the dealer back, snatching the keys off the console. He tapped his earpiece as he ran toward the docks. *"Grisel, I stashed the package. I got a skiff and a lead. Stay in the shadows, I'm coming to get you."*

CHAPTER 4: THE BUTCHER AND THE EXTRACTION

The black water of the submarine docks was freezing, but Eigor didn't feel it. HisTimberite skin hardened against the pressure as he swam deeper, tracing the localized ping of Brox's chassis.

He found the Breaker sub anchored in the deep dark, tethered to a rusted pillar. Eigor slipped through the compromised airlock. Inside, the chattering, rhythmic screeching of the hive was deafening. The hallway was packed with converted hosts—mercenaries, transients, scrappers—all moving with synchronized, terrifying purpose.

Eigor stepped directly into their path.

The Breakers didn't attack. They parted around him like a current around a stone. The hive mind was purely utilitarian; Timberite physiology was incompatible with the Breaker neural-shunt. Without organic nerve clusters to hijack, Eigor wasn't a potential host. To the virus, he was simply an inert object.

He found Brox in the holding bay, his cybernetic legs locked in a rigid march. Eigor moved fast. He sliced his own palm, the pale tendrils whipping out and plunging into the exposed necks of two nearby Breakers. Eigor instantly seized their motor functions, forcing the hijacked mercenaries to hurl three other Breakers across the room, creating a momentary clearing.

Before the hive could recalibrate to the physical obstruction, Eigor tackled Brox. The Breaker hardware inside Brox screeched, his mechanical limbs thrashing violently, but Eigor was stronger. He pinned Brox to the deck, wrapping heavy industrial zip-cable around his arms and legs, binding him into a rigid cocoon. Eigor hoisted the thrashing, screeching body over his shoulder, abandoned the hijacked guards, and plunged back into the freezing water.

Aboard the Howling vessel, safely away from the docks, Eigor dropped the bound Brox onto the metal grating of the cargo hold. Brox's mechanical jaw clamped open and shut, emitting a constant, digital shriek.

Grisel stood over him, her 4-foot-10 frame rigid, her fists clenched at her sides. She stared at the optics of his mask. She knew he was awake in there. Trapped. Watching her.

"I found a dealer in Canary," Eigor said, wiping the black water from his bark-like face. "He claims a Stillous was captured a few months ago. The hive tried to convert him, but his people came down and extracted him. They fixed him, Grisel. The Stillous have a way to scramble the host-lock without killing the brain."

Grisel looked up. "Where?"

"There's a Stillous gang leader operating out of the eastern scrap-reefs. A rogue named Varnis. He runs a mobile carrier, heavily armed, and he has ties up high," Eigor explained, moving toward the airlock. "I have a rendezvous ship for you—a scum pirate runner heading his way. I need to take the Howling ship to secure the chest and find a way to crack the Onyx locks. You take Brox to the runner."

Grisel looked down at the violently thrashing chassis on the floor. The heavy zip-cables were already fraying against the sheer torque of Brox's servos. "He'll tear a transport skiff apart. I can't carry him like this, Eigor. Not alone."

Eigor didn't say a word. He just gave her a grim, knowing nod, and climbed the ladder to the bridge.

Grisel knelt beside Brox. She pulled a heavy plasma-cutter and a socket wrench from her belt. Her hands were shaking. "I know you're in there, Brox," she whispered, her gravelly voice cracking. "I know you can see me. I'm sorry. But I'm going to get you back."

She clamped the wrench onto the primary bolt of his left shoulder prosthetic. The Breaker hardware registered the interference, and Brox's arm jerked violently. It snagged on a fused tendon, the metal refusing to give. Grisel gritted her teeth. She planted her heavy, clawed foot squarely against Brox's chest chassis, gripped the arm with both hands, and leveraged her entire Howling weight backward.

With a sickening *CRACK*, the shoulder joint severed.

Ten miles to the east, the scum pirate runner bobbed lazily in the grey waters.

A shadow fell over the deck. The pirate crew looked up to see a massive Onyx Empire Galleon pulling alongside them, its sleek, black-armored hull dwarfing their rusted ship. A hydraulic boarding bridge slammed down onto the pirate deck with a deafening crash.

Dozens of Onyx soldiers marched across, their polished boots moving in perfect unison. They didn't draw their weapons. They simply shoved the terrified pirate crew aside, marching straight toward the entrance of the cargo hold.

"Hey! State your business!" one of the pirate officers yelled, stepping in front of the door.

An Onyx lieutenant shoved the man backward, throwing his gaze up to the bridge. "Captain! Open these doors!"

Grisel zipped the massive canvas backpack closed. Inside were the heavy, bloody cybernetics of Brox's four severed limbs.

She stood in front of his remaining torso. Without his limbs, the Breaker hardware could only force his chest to heave and his head to snap back and forth. Grisel pulled a length of medical tubing from a med-kit. She bypassed the filter mask, threading the tube directly into his nutrient port, pumping a bag of thick, brown protein sludge and water into his stomach.

She took a heavy mechanical neck-clamp. Looking into the whirring fans of his optics one last time, she twisted his head into a neutral position and locked the clamp shut. The physical connection to his motor-cortex was throttled. Brox’s torso finally went completely, eerily still.

"I don't kneel for the Empire!" the pirate captain's voice boomed over the runner's loudspeakers. "Get off my ship!"

Aboard the Onyx Galleon, deep in the lower cargo hold, a heavy vault door hissed open.

Inside the cage was a Wraithlion. It was a massive, cybernetic apex predator, plated in deep blue alloy. Hydraulic pistons, thick as tree trunks, hissed along its forelegs. Its jaw hung slightly open, revealing rows of teeth that vibrated with a terrifying, high-frequency hum—like an oscillating reciprocating saw.

The Onyx handler approached, unhooking the primary static-leash from the cage. The Wraithlion stepped forward. It didn't lunge. It merely broke into a casual walking stride toward the boarding ramp, but the sheer kinetic torque of its muscles jolted the handler forward, forcing the soldier into a panicked jog just to keep from being dragged across the deck.

The Howling ship lowered a small, motorized raft into the churning ocean.

Grisel stepped down into the unsteady boat. The massive backpack of limbs sat heavy on the floorboards around her boots. Strapped tightly to her back, hanging like a macabre, heavy papoose, was Brox’s limbless torso and clamped head.

"Two hours east!" Eigor yelled from the deck above, pulling the Howling ship's anchor. "I'll find you when the chest is secure!"

Grisel nodded, revving the outboard engine. The Howling ship immediately began to drift southeast, peeling away into the fog. Grisel locked her eyes on the eastern horizon and hit the throttle, fighting the harsh, chopping waves.

The Wraithlion stepped off the boarding bridge and onto the pirate runner.

The low, vibrating hum of its oscillating teeth filled the air. The pirate crew backed away slowly, trembling, their backs pressing against the gunwales.

One pirate’s nerve broke. He screamed, vaulted the railing, and threw his legs over, pushing off toward the open water.

Before his body even reached the apex of its arc, the Wraithlion dashed. It covered sixty feet in two seconds—an instantaneous blue blur of pistons and alloy. It intercepted the pirate in mid-air over the water. The reciprocating jaws

snapped shut. There was no scream. In less than a second, the pirate was shredded into a cloud of red mist and pulverized bone, painting the side of the hull in a long, horrific streak.

The Wraithlion landed perfectly on the railing, turning its glowing optics back to the remaining crew.

The Onyx lieutenant twirled his finger in the air. "Sweep."

The beast vanished. It became a localized storm of kinetic violence. It hit the crew one by one, combining its dashing momentum with the reciprocating jaws. Within sixteen seconds, the entire upper deck was cleared. Where twenty men had stood, there were only puddles of liquefied flesh, shattered chrome, and pooling blood.

The Wraithlion effortlessly scaled the bulkhead, shattering the heavy iron door of the captain's bridge. The captain scrambled backward, slamming his hand onto his console to send out a blind distress ping.

A second later, the oscillating teeth took his head.

Miles away, alone on the vast, churning ocean, the distress ping chimed quietly on Grisel’s comms unit.

She didn't reach up to answer it. She kept her hands firmly on the raft's tiller, ignoring the harsh saltwater spraying across her face. The Onyx Galleon was already pulling away from the pirate runner, leaving a silent, floating slaughterhouse in its wake.

Grisel just rode the swells, carrying the pieces of the man she loved directly toward the graveyard.

ARCHIVAL FRAGMENT: MARKET RULE & THE ECHIDNA DOCTRINE (2511)

Origin: *Orbital Census and Trade Authority, Lunar Sector 4, Year 2511*

> By the 2300s, Earth was legally severed from the greater Sol system. Orbit, the lunar settlements, and the transit lanes fell under Market Rule, a system anchored entirely in traditional Stillous philosophy. To the Stillous, the universe offers only two acceptable states of being: absolute privacy in isolation, or absolute devotion to communal advancement. Property reflects this. Purchasing land in Sol pays a direct dividend into a pool divided evenly among the sector's residents.
>
> Stillous society is infinitely more fractured and varied than humanity ever was. A lunar settlement might hold millions, but it is divided into localized cohorts of a few thousand. These cohorts function as absolute, immediate families. They breed through community and encourage their young to migrate to prevent stagnation. Within a cohort, their rules are sovereign. If a specific family tradition dictates that their young must fight to the death in arenas for entertainment, neighboring Stillous do not intervene. It is simply not their place.
>
> Earthlings who migrated to space had to adapt to this extreme moral relativism. Factions like the Howlings initially attempted to establish universal governments with baseline laws. They failed. Forced to navigate the rigid boundaries of Stillous privacy, human alliances fractured, dividing into tribal cohorts that ultimately mirrored the aliens they tried to regulate.
>
> This cultural isolationism bled back down to Earth, culminating in the Mirlyns. Emerging in the 2400s from a middle caste of Rhombus and Howlings, the Mirlyns altered their baseline genetics using the ancient archives of Echidna, the Stillous homeworld orbiting the planet Typhon.

The Mirlyns adopted the extreme privacy of the Stillous cohorts but stripped away any underlying compassion. They are a dark, fiercely homogenous species. Claiming the last remaining pockets of unirradiated land in the northwest hemisphere, they built iron barricades and adopted a strict shoot-on-sight doctrine. To maintain their isolation, they control two of Earth’s fifteen shuttle ports. The Onyx Empire holds five in the south. The Stillous operate the remaining eight. These vertical launch ports remain the only physical bridges between the flooded world and the absolute freedom of Sol.

CHAPTER 5: THE BUTCHER'S WAKE

The pirate runner was drifting sideways against the current when Grisel finally cut her raft’s engine.

The silence over the water was heavy. No engine hum, no crew shouting from the deck. Just the rhythmic slapping of the ocean against the rusted hull. Grisel tied her raft to the runner’s boarding ladder. The heavy canvas backpack sitting on the floorboards shifted slightly.

"We're here," Grisel muttered.

She hoisted the backpack over her shoulder. The weight of Brox’s four severed limbs pulled at her posture, but she absorbed it. Then, she reached down and hoisted the harness holding Brox’s torso. She strapped him tightly to her chest, securing his clamped head against her collarbone. The feeding tube taped to his neck pulsed slightly with the pressure of her movements. He was dead weight, but the faint vibration of his internal servos told her he was still awake inside the shell.

Grisel climbed the ladder one-handed, her claws finding purchase on the slick iron rungs.

She crested the railing and stepped onto the deck. The smell hit her first—copper, raw meat, and ozone. Her stomach turned.

The deck was a slaughterhouse. There were no bodies, only pieces. Pools of liquefied flesh and shattered chrome painted the floorboards and the bulkheads. Weapons lay abandoned in the sludge. The captain's door above the bridge had been torn off its hinges, the iron frame bent inward like foil.

Grisel didn't draw her flail. There was no point. Whatever did this was already gone, and it hadn't left anything alive to fight.

She stepped carefully through the wreckage, her boots sticking to the deck. She checked the cargo hold first. Empty. The supply lockers had been ripped open, rations and water purifiers stripped clean. It wasn't just a massacre; it was a methodical sweep.

"Onyx," Gris whispered to herself, spotting a perfectly clean, deep-tread boot print stamped into a puddle of blood near the railing. "They sent a Wraithlion."

She moved up the stairs to the bridge, avoiding the mess where the captain used to be. The control console was dark, save for a single blinking amber light. The distress ping. The captain had slammed it before he died, but the Onyx had taken the ship's primary comms array, rendering the runner dead in the water.

Grisel slumped against the wall of the bridge, sliding down until she sat on the cold floor. The sheer scale of the ocean outside the broken windows felt crushing. She was on a dead ship, thousands of miles from the eastern scrap-reefs, carrying a man who couldn't scream.

She reached up, resting her hand against the cold metal of Brox's cheek.

"Eigor is getting the chest," Gris said quietly to the quiet room. "And I'm getting you to Varnis. We just have to find a way to make this bucket move."

She closed her eyes, the exhaustion of the last twelve hours finally bleeding into her muscles. She needed to wire the runner's backup battery to the engines, but right now, she just needed ten minutes of sleep.

A sharp, metallic *clatter* echoed from the lower decks.

Grisel's eyes snapped open. The exhaustion vanished, replaced instantly by cold adrenaline. She didn't stand up. She reached down, unspooling the chain of her flail without making a sound.

Someone was still on the ship.

CHAPTER 6: THE SALVAGE CREW

Grisel didn't mean to close her eyes for long, but her exhausted body betrayed her. When she finally woke, the angle of the grey light cutting through the shattered bridge windows told her hours had passed.

It wasn't a threat that woke her. It was a steady, rhythmic scraping sound from the main deck.

Grisel unspooled her flail, letting the chain slide silently through her claws. She crept to the top of the stairs, keeping her profile low.

Down on the deck, a lanky man in grease-stained overalls was casually pushing a heavy industrial broom, sweeping the congealed red sludge of the pirate crew toward the scuppers.

Grisel shifted her weight, a floorboard groaning under her foot.

The man didn't look up from his sweeping. "It's messy, but it's a free ship," he called out, his voice relaxed. "There's no way you were here when this happened, so I won't bother asking. Figured you were just trying to head somewhere."

Grisel stepped out of the shadows, her grip tight on the iron handle. "You knew I was up there?"

"Didn't want to wake you," he said, finally leaning on his broom. He wiped sweat from his forehead with a rag. "Figured we'd be working down here for a while anyway."

Grisel slowly descended the stairs, keeping her distance. "Did you guys notice the batteries are—"

"Yeah, we clocked that," the man interrupted, waving the rag dismissively. "Did you happen to notice the primary piston is offset by about two bulkheads? Or the four-liter-an-hour leak in the lower hull?"

Grisel looked at the deep claw marks gouged into the steel doorframes. "Had to be a Wraithlion, right?"

"Probably. Fast and thorough," the man said. "I'm Vane. Tess and Barrett are below fixing the engine." Vane pointed over the railing. Tied to the pirate runner was a small, heavily battered salvage boat. It was piled so high with scavenged machinery, scrap metal, and tools that the waterline was dangerously close to spilling over the gunwales.

Vane looked back at Grisel, sizing her up. "I'll make it simple. If you want claim of this vessel, you can compensate us for the work we're putting in."

Grisel shook her head. "This fine craft is all yours. I only ask you don't toss us into the ocean."

Vane frowned, his eyes narrowing. "What do you mean, 'us'? I only saw you sleeping up there."

"Wait here," Grisel said.

She turned and marched back up to the bridge. A minute later, she reappeared at the top of the stairs. She had the heavy canvas backpack slung over one shoulder, and both hands gripping the harness that held Brox. She carried the limbless torso down the steps, the heavy mechanical neck-clamp gleaming in the dull light.

Vane dropped his broom. The wooden handle clattered loudly against the deck.

"What the hell is that?" Vane took a slow step backward, his hand hovering near a heavy wrench on his belt. "It has... he has feeding tubes. That's alive. He's alive, isn't he? Why are you keeping a Breaker alive?"

"He's disabled," Grisel said, setting Brox down carefully against the bulkhead. The twin fans on his mask whirred steadily. "I severed the motor-cortex connection. He can't move, and he can't transmit."

"It's a mechanical virus!" Vane yelled, his relaxed demeanor completely vanishing. "You don't keep them as pets!"

Heavy footsteps echoed from the lower deck hatch. Two figures emerged, both covered in engine grease and rust dust. Tess was short, wired with tense energy, wiping her hands on a rag. Barrett was huge, sporting a patched synthetic eye.

"Vane, who are you yelling at?" Tess asked, looking up. Then she saw the torso resting against the wall. She stopped dead. "Are you kidding me?"

Vane gestured wildly at Grisel. "She was asleep on the bridge. She wants passage in exchange for the ship. And she's carrying a live, butchered Breaker."

Barrett stared at Brox, then slowly looked down at the canvas bag leaking fluid onto the deck. "Are the rest of his pieces in the bag?"

"Yes," Grisel said flatly. "I'm taking him to the eastern scrap-reefs. Someone there can fix him."

Tess let out a sharp, incredulous laugh. "Nobody fixes them, greenie. Once the shunt goes in, the meat is just a passenger. You're lugging a corpse that doesn't know it's dead yet."

"He's in there," Grisel growled, her hand dropping back to her flail. "And I'm getting him there. You want the ship or not?"

Barrett nudged Tess with his elbow, staring at the torso. "Would you do that for me?"

Tess looked at him like he was an idiot. "Hell no. But I can skip right to chopping you into pieces right now if you want."

Barrett frowned, crossing his massive arms. "That's mean. I'd try to save you if you got infected."

"That's because I'm useful, Bear," Tess shot back, tossing her dirty rag at his chest. "I'm the only one who knows how to calibrate the intake valves. If I go Breaker, you sink. If you go Breaker, I just buy a winch."

"It's the principle of the thing," Barrett muttered.

Vane pinched the bridge of his nose, exhaling a long, tired breath. He looked at the overloaded salvage boat, then at the massive Onyx-cleared runner, and finally at Grisel.

"Fine," Vane said. "But he stays strapped to the mast, out in the open. If that thing even twitches in a way I don't like, I'm throwing it overboard. And you're helping Tess with the offset piston."

Grisel nodded, picking Brox up by the harness. "Deal."

CHAPTER 7: THE FENCER

Eigor woke to the dull vibration of his comms unit buzzing against the iron bedside table. He sat up, his stiff Timberite joints cracking slightly in the damp air of the Port Canary safehouse.

He tapped the receiver. It was an encrypted text-burst from Grisel. *Runner wiped by Onyx. Wraithlion. Found a salvage crew. Trading repairs for passage east. Brox is secure in pieces. Moving.*

Eigor exhaled a long breath. She had sailed directly into the Empire's teeth and somehow walked out with a ride.

He looked at the floorboards, beneath which the biometric locker held the Onyx chest. It was a gravity well. The further south he went, the thicker the Empire patrols became. Holding an Onyx tax collection was a death sentence. He needed to fence it, take the cut, and buy their way off the rock before the Empire tracked the energy signature of the docks back to them.

There was only one faction on Earth with enough capital to buy it and enough firepower to tell the Onyx Empire to go to hell. The Mirlyns.

Eigor grabbed his coat and left the safehouse.

Port Canary was waking up. He navigated the rusted catwalks and narrow alleys until he reached a scrap-broker front operating out of a hollowed-out desalination tank.

Flint was behind the counter, weighing a pile of copper shunts. He was a baseline human, older, with a network of burn scars crawling up his neck. He looked up, his eyes darting to the door before settling on Eigor.

"You're making a lot of noise for a guy who just pulled into port," Flint said, tossing the shunts into a bin.

"I need to move something," Eigor said, stepping up to the counter.

Flint wiped his hands on a rag. "Bring it in. I'll take it off your hands."

"You don't have the vault for this, Flint," Eigor said flatly. "And you don't want the heat that comes with it."

Flint stopped wiping his hands. He looked closely at Eigor's stoic, bark-like face. "What are you fucking with, Timber?"

"I'm offering a finder's fee," Eigor said, ignoring the question. "I need an introduction to a Mirlyn."

Flint winced. He tossed the rag onto the counter and shook his head. "They don't take meetings. They shoot trespassers and burn the bodies. You know that."

"Someone acts as a go-between," Eigor said. "They still need Earth tech and raw materials. Who moves it for them?"

Flint stared at him for a long moment, weighing the risk. "There's a mechanic. A Rhombus. Lives out in the borderlands on his own compound. Built a fortress out of junk. He trades with them. Only guy I know who can walk up to a Mirlyn wall without catching a rail-slug to the chest."

"Contact him," Eigor said.

"I can send a ping," Flint replied, leaning on the counter. "If he answers, you work it out from there. But a ping to the borderlands isn't cheap."

Flint held his hand out, palm up.

Eigor reached into his coat. He pulled out three Gloves, each tightly wrapped in lead-lined mesh to mask their energy output. He dropped them into Flint's waiting hand. They hit with a heavy, solid thud.

Flint's eyes widened. He quickly closed his fist, slipping the Gloves beneath the counter out of sight.

"Make sure he hits me back," Eigor said.

ARCHIVAL FRAGMENT: THE RHOMBUS AND THE DEAD WATERS (2614)

Origin: *Typhon-Earth Ecological Survey, Year 2614*

> The Rhombus did not evolve; they iterated. Prioritizing pure scientific optimization, they systematically engineered their own genome to strip away biological inefficiencies, including baseline human empathy. Driven by unchecked experimentation, they became a society of brilliant, unhinged engineers.
>
> The ecological cost of their advancement is incalculable. They treated the flooded Earth as a limitless dumping ground, choking the northern waters with chemical pollution and failed biomechanical experiments. Their most infamous creation, the Breaker virus, remains a global plague. However, the waters immediately surrounding Rhombus territory host an equally terrifying deterrent: the Incinerator Swarms.
>
> These are thousands of self-replicating, autonomous swimming bots. Operating on a primitive hive-logic, they detect the displacement of large hulls. Once triggered, a swarm can surround and systematically melt down a heavy ship in minutes.
>
> Navigating Rhombus waters requires a specific vessel known as a Skid. It is a hyper-lightcraft utilizing submerged propulsion fins that slice the water without triggering displacement sensors. The driver cab sits elevated above the surface. Capable of holding only one or two passengers, the Skid trades armor for absolute stealth. It is the only way through the dead waters.

Eigor scrolled through the local scrap-listings on his comms unit, leaning against the cold iron of the Port Canary safehouse. He needed a Skid.

Specifically, he needed a Skid capable of balancing a two-hundred-kilo payload without dipping its displacement fins too low. Buying anything from a Rhombus broker was a massive risk. They were notorious grifters, prone to hardwiring kill-switches into their engines just to salvage the vessel after the buyer drowned. Flint was reliable, but Eigor knew that courtesy rarely extended to his references.

His comms unit chimed. A text-burst from an unregistered local node.

how far are you from the triple peaks?

Eigor stared at the screen. The Triple Peaks were a cluster of jagged, highly irradiated atolls on the edge of the borderlands. He typed back. *Two days. Why would I go out there?*

That's where I live. Just outside.

Eigor frowned, his wooden features rigid. *Why would I bring it to you? Flint just said you could broker a meeting.*

Because I know how to open the chest.

Eigor froze. He hadn't told Flint what he was carrying, only that he needed a Mirlyn buyer. *I didn't say I had a chest.*

You didn't have to, the response came instantly. *A massive kinetic blast in the dirty docks wipes an Onyx tax skiff. Two hours later, a Timberite starts asking about high-end fencing with the Mirlyns. I was waiting for whoever walked away with the payload to surface. You can't fence it closed. The Mirlyns will just kill you and take it.*

Eigor tapped his thumb against the screen. *And you can open it?*

I was contracted by the security firm that designed the housing, the Rhombus replied. *It's double-sealed, harder than diamond, and rigged with a pressurized caustic defense. Try to cut it, and it melts the scripts inside and your face simultaneously. Buy a heavy Skid. Come to the Peaks.*

Eigor closed the connection. He looked down at the floorboards hiding the chest. If Remo was lying, Eigor was driving into a trap. If Remo was telling the truth, it was the only way to get the money out intact.

He grabbed his coat and headed back to the scrap-broker. He had a Skid to buy.

The ocean was flat and grey, the silence broken only by the steady, rhythmic hum of the pirate runner's offset engine.

At the helm, Vane leaned casually against the steering column. He checked the horizon, then looked over his shoulder.

Grisel was asleep on a pile of canvas tarps near the stairwell. She hadn't moved in three hours. Propped up against the steel bulkhead, perfectly upright and bolted into his harness, was Brox's limbless torso. The feeding tube pulsed faintly. The dual fans of his optics whirred, staring straight ahead at the bridge.

Vane looked at the horizon. Then he looked back at Brox. He did a double-take, catching the faint reflection of the control panel in the glass of Brox's mask.

Vane cleared his throat. "I, uh. I wish you the best, man."

Brox's fans spun. He did not move.

"I mean, I don't know how much you're tracking in there," Vane continued, leaning his elbow on the console. "Tess says the lights are on but nobody's home. But Grisel seems pretty sure. And she's terrifying, so I'll take her word for it."

Silence.

"It's a tough break," Vane said, pulling a crushed pack of stim-gum from his overalls. He popped a piece into his mouth. "I almost lost my arm to a threshing gear a few years back. Not the same as having them all popped off by your girlfriend, obviously. But I get the vulnerability."

Vane chewed the gum, staring out at the water. The isolation of the open ocean always made him talkative.

"You know, my cousin bought a Rhombus implant once," Vane rambled, gesturing vaguely with his free hand. "Just a baseline ocular upgrade. Said it would help him spot salvage. Damn thing shorted out during a monsoon. Locked his vision entirely on infrared. He spent three weeks trying to date a thermal exhaust vent because he thought it was a woman waving at him." Vane chuckled. "Took us a month to afford the removal surgery. He still asks about the vent sometimes."

Vane paused, looking over his shoulder, waiting for a laugh.

Brox stared forward, the mechanical neck-clamp holding his head perfectly rigid. The central grill over his mouth hissed a sterile breath of air.

"Yeah, you probably had to be there," Vane muttered, turning back to the wheel.

Five minutes passed.

"The thing is," Vane started again, fully turning around now to face the torso, "I don't think Tess respects my mechanical input. She treats me like I'm just the mop guy. But I found the four-liter leak in the hull, didn't I? I told her, 'Tess, if you don't patch the starboard intake, we're going to list.' And what did she say?" Vane threw his hands up. "She said, 'Shut up, Vane.' Can you believe that?"

Vane leaned in closer to Brox, waiting for a response. "Right? It's all ego with her."

A heavy, clawed hand suddenly clamped onto Vane's shoulder.

Vane yelped, nearly jumping out of his boots. He spun around. Grisel was standing right behind him, her green eyes narrowed, looking thoroughly unamused.

"He thinks you're an idiot, Vane," Grisel growled. "Keep your eyes on the water."

Vane swallowed hard, his hands tightening on the steering wheel. He offered Grisel a nervous, lopsided smile. "Right. Well, good to know you speak for him now."

Grisel didn't smile back.

Vane cleared his throat and pointed through the salt-stained glass of the bridge. "Good timing, anyway. We're here."

Grisel stepped up to the console and looked out. Rising from the grey fog of the eastern scrap-reefs was a titan of the old world. It was an ancient, pre-flood aircraft carrier, its massive flat deck towering above the water. Years of survival had transformed it from a military vessel into a floating, rusted metropolis. The hull was stained with salt and vibrant, overlapping layers of territorial graffiti. Sparks rained down into the ocean from dozens of men dangling in makeshift harnesses, welding scrap iron plates to reinforce the decaying water line.

"Drop me at the lower gantry," Grisel said, already turning to gather her things.

She hoisted the heavy canvas bag over her shoulder. Then she knelt and strapped Brox’s limbless torso to her chest, securing the mechanical neck-clamp tightly against her collarbone. The fans in his mask whirred steadily against her neck.

Vane pulled the runner alongside a rusted pontoon at the base of the carrier. He didn't ask for a goodbye. Grisel stepped off the boat and immediately began the long chug up the switchback stairs welded to the exterior hull.

Her legs burned. Carrying her own bags was one thing, but hauling Brox’s chassis and the dead weight of his severed limbs up eighty feet of vertical grating was agonizing.

She reached the top and stepped onto the flight deck.

The noise was absolute. The deck was a sprawling, chaotic bazaar packed shoulder-to-shoulder with thousands of people. Scavengers, drifters, violent gang enforcers, and Stillous rejects all pushed through a maze of canvas tents and scrap-metal stalls. The air choked her with the smell of roasting meat, engine exhaust, and unwashed bodies.

Grisel forced her way into the crush, keeping her head down. She had no idea where she was going or who to ask. She just pushed forward, using her broad shoulders to clear a path.

Suddenly, the canvas bag on her shoulder jerked violently.

Grisel stumbled, spinning around just in time to see a filthy, scarred hand disappear into the crowd. The heavy zipper of the bag had been torn open. Brox’s left cybernetic arm was gone.

"Hey!" Grisel roared, her voice a deep, guttural bark that turned a few heads. She unspooled her flail, taking a threatening step into the crowd. "Who took it?!"

The crowd just stared back with indifferent, hollow eyes. The thief was already swallowed by the mass of bodies. In a place like this, a high-end cybernetic arm was worth a year of rations.

Grisel gritted her teeth, her knuckles turning white around the iron handle of her flail. She wanted to crack skulls until the arm surfaced, but she couldn't risk a riot. Not while carrying Brox. She swallowed her rage, pulled the torn canvas bag to her front, and clutched it against her stomach alongside Brox's torso.

She scanned the massive deck, looking for authority. Toward the aft of the ship, elevated above the squalor on what used to be the command tower, was a private, heavily guarded terrace. Standing at the railing was a Stillous. He was incredibly tall, even for his kind, and unnaturally lanky. His scaly skin was a faded, ashen grey, marred by deep, jagged scars that no Stillous healer had bothered to mend.

Varnis.

Grisel pushed her way through the last of the crowd and marched up the metal ramp leading to the VIP deck. At the top of the ramp stood a guard. He was a baseline human, but built like a brick wall, wearing thick composite armor and holding a heavy scattergun.

He held up a hand, stepping into her path.

"I'm Griselda," she said, breathing heavily.

The guard looked down at her. He looked at the torn bag clutched to her stomach, and the whirring, limbless cyborg strapped to her chest.

"Huh," the guard grunted.

"I'm here to see Varnis," Grisel said, standing her ground.

"Good for you," the guard replied lazily, chewing on a matchstick. "Now step back before I throw you and your scrap-pile off the flight deck."

"A Timberite named Eigor sent me," Grisel pushed, refusing to move. "Tell Varnis I have a Breaker. Tell him I know about the host-lock."

The guard stopped chewing. He stared at her for a long moment, his eyes shifting from her green skin to the dual optics of Brox's mask. He tapped the comms bead in his ear.

"Got a Howling down here," the guard muttered into the mic. "Says she was sent by a Timber. Has a dismantled Breaker strapped to her chest... Yeah. Understood."

The guard dropped his hand from his ear and stepped aside, gesturing lazily toward the heavy steel door behind him with the barrel of his scattergun.

"He's in a good mood today," the guard said. "Try not to ruin it."

Grisel adjusted the heavy load on her chest and walked through the door.

The heavy steel door closed behind Grisel, shutting out the roar of the flight deck.

Miles away, at the blind end of a forgotten Port Canary dock, Eigor pulled a thick canvas tarp over the Onyx chest. He wrenched the heavy ratchet straps tight, securing the two-hundred-kilo payload to the center of the Skid. The lightcraft dipped low in the water, its displacement fins hovering dangerously close to the threshold. Eigor climbed into the elevated driver cab, primed the silent engine, and slipped out into the fog.

Back on the carrier, Grisel took in the room. It was surprisingly sparse. Varnis stood at a metal desk near the far wall, methodically piecing together a glass cylinder.

Varnis didn't look up. "I heard him tell you I was in a good mood. Don't get your hopes up. Eigor told me the issue."

He stopped tinkering and turned. His ashen, scaly face was unreadable. He looked at the torn canvas bag clutched to Grisel's stomach.

"He only has a right hand?" Varnis asked.

"Someone snatched his left arm on the way to the door," Grisel said.

Varnis let out a slow, raspy sigh. "Savages. This is why I stay private. What did he look like?"

"No idea, really," Grisel replied.

Varnis walked past her toward one of the composite-armored guards standing near the entrance. "Can you find the left arm? Go ahead and snatch the arm of the guy holding it too. His own arm."

The guard nodded once and slipped out the door.

Grisel shifted her stance. "So we're all in a bad mood. That's fine. You at least must have some good news. No reason to get the arm back unless you plan on putting him back together, right?"

Varnis walked over to a side table, poured a dark liquid into a glass, and slammed it back in one swallow. "Two things need to happen. Obviously, I need the scripts Eigor promised. Second, I need the anti-Host-lock."

He set the glass down hard. "I know if you had the money, you would have offered it by now. That's no problem, because if I expected it, I wouldn't be letting you waste my time. Your scrap pile here, and three of my best dudes down below, need that hardware. It should have arrived before you got here. Before Eigor even contacted me. I assumed he heard something."

Grisel frowned, a cold knot forming in her stomach. "What hardware?"

"A secure transport," Varnis said, leaning against his desk. "Double-sealed casing, pressurized caustic defense. It was moving south through the dirty docks. Inside isn't just tax money, Griselda. The Empire confiscated the only working prototypes of the Breaker reversal tech. I paid a crew to hit the skiff, but they went dark."

Grisel stopped breathing. Eigor hadn't stolen retirement money. He had stolen the cure. And he was driving it directly to a Rhombus grifter in the borderlands to fence it.

The ocean was pitch black.

Eigor drove the Skid at full throttle through the incinerator territory. The submerged fins sliced the water cleanly, keeping the hull elevated just enough to avoid triggering the displacement sensors of the swimming swarms below.

The wind howled through the open cab. Eigor’s eyelids began to fall, the sheer physical toll of the last forty-eight hours dragging him down. He slapped the side of his wooden face, forcing his eyes open, pushing the throttle forward. Just a few more hours to the Triple Peaks.

Out of the suffocating dark to the north, three quick flashes of violet light strobed across the horizon.

Before Eigor's brain could register the threat, the water around the Skid erupted.

Three Mirlyn seeker rounds slammed into the craft. The kinetic force shattered the Skid's starboard fin. The lightcraft spun violently out of control, the chassis buckling as the nose violently dug into the water. Eigor was ripped from the cab. He flew through the air, slamming hard into the freezing, turbulent ocean, leaving his ruined craft and the strapped-down chest drifting in the dark.

CHAPTER 8: THE PIRATES OF ECHIDNA

The Mirlyn pirate ship cut through the black waves like a blade. It didn't look built; it looked grown. Dark, jagged iron and composite sails loomed against the night sky.

On the deck, the crew moved in absolute silence. They were vile, vampiric figures, born from a brutal cocktail of human survivalism and Stillous isolationist genetics. Most possessed wide, leathery wings grafted tightly against their backs, their limbs replaced with sharp, angular cybernetics meant for tearing rather than gripping. They were the apex predators of the open sea—the only faction violent enough to keep the Onyx Empire in check.

Hanging from the lower yardarms of the sails were dozens of heavy, pulsing sacks.

As the ship banked sharply to intercept Eigor's drifting Skid, one of the sacks tore. It busted open against the deck with a wet, heavy slap.

A few dozen Mirlyn newborns spilled out, covered in thick amniotic sludge. They were small, pale, and feral, already snapping their jaws.

A winged crewman walked past. He didn't offer a hand. Instead, he grabbed a heavy push broom and callously swept the squirming mass of newborns straight off the side of the ship.

Most of the newborns hit the water and immediately sank, drowning in the cold dark. But a few fought. They dug tiny, vicious claws into the rusted iron hull, screeching as they climbed against the freezing spray. The crewman watched indifferently as two lost their grip and fell back into the wake.

Only one made it over the railing. It hit the deck shivering, its eyes wide and black. The crewman stepped forward, raising his boot, and chased the terrified survivor into a dark corner beneath the stairs. The test was over. It had earned its right to live.

A Mirlyn with a cybernetic jaw stepped to the bow, looking down at the crippled Skid and the Onyx chest secured to its frame. They didn't cheer. They didn't speak. Mirlyns only screamed when they went in for the kill.

The captain raised a hand, signaling the crew to drop the boarding hooks.